

UNIT 1 Writing a Cover Letter

When you apply for a job, you need to send a résumé and a cover letter. A résumé is a written list that describes your education and the jobs you have had. (A sample résumé is in the reference section of this book on page 134.) A cover letter introduces you to the person who is hiring for the job.

Before you write the cover letter, you need information about the job, especially the qualifications needed. The best place to find this information is in the advertisement where you learned about the job.

GETTING STARTED

1. Read the two job advertisements. Pay attention to the qualifications needed.
2. Complete the Job Requirements Chart. Write a check (✔) if the job advertisement asks for the requirement.
3. Write a check (✔) if *your* skills match the requirement.

http://www.netlives.com

NetLives

The ADMINISTRATIVE ASSISTANT will work with the general manager. The individual will manage schedules, order supplies, prepare expense reports, and perform general word processing. The admin. asst. will be responsible for mailings, faxes, photocopying, and filing.

A high school degree and a minimum of 2 years of experience are required.

NetLives offers a fun, dynamic, and innovative work environment.

Contact Information
Maria Sanchez
Human Resource Specialist
msanchez@netlives.com

NetLives Ltd.
632 Garrison Road
Cambridge CB4 1HD
Tel: 1223 334566
Fax: 1223 534987

About NetLives

Administrative Assistant

A local Internet service provider has a full-time position available for an administrative assistant. This individual will perform general administrative duties. Candidates must be familiar with word processing programs. Successful candidates must also have excellent communication skills. A college degree is a must. Salary: $25,000 to $35,000 per year.
E-mail résumé to resumespptsrvc@acaison.net.

JOB REQUIREMENTS CHART

Web site Ad	Newspaper Ad	Requirement	Your Skills
(1)		Will perform general administrative duties such as photocopying and filing.	
(2)		Will have a college degree.	
(3)		Must be familiar with word processing programs.	
(4)		Will have at least 2 years of experience as an administrative assistant.	
(5)		Must have excellent communication skills.	

Model Cover Letter

Look at the different elements of a cover letter.

Return Address
This is your personal letterhead. Put your contact information here.

Michele Peters
45 Agate Road
London NW6 0AH
Tel: 208 847 9746
Fax: 208 774 8094
E-mail: mpeters@londonmail.com

Date

March 1, 20—

Inside Address
Write a cover letter to a specific person, if possible.

Maria Sanchez
Human Resource Specialist
NetLives Ltd.
632 Garrison Road
Cambridge CB4 1HD

Salutation
Use a colon after the name.

Dear Ms. Sanchez:

Opening
Tell (1) that you are applying for a job and (2) the source of your information.

I read about a job opening for an administrative assistant on the NetLives Web site.

Focus
Tell why you are suited for the job.

I am a recent graduate of EMP Secretarial School, and I was in the top of my class. I am looking for a challenging work environment like that at NetLives.

Action
Tell what you plan to do.

I will call you next Monday to discuss my enclosed résumé.

Closing
Be positive.

I look forward to meeting with you soon.

Complimentary Close

Sincerely yours,

Signature
Sign your name.

Michele Peters

Typed Name

Michele Peters

Enclosure
Add this if you are sending something with the letter.

Enclosure

Useful Language

I read about a job opening for _____.

I will call you _____.

I look forward to meeting you.

Composing Your Message

The body of a cover letter generally has four parts.

Part	Content	Example
Opening	Tell (1) that you are applying for a job and (2) the source of your information.	I read about a job opening for an administrative assistant on the NetLives Web site.
Focus	Tell why you are suited for the job.	I am a recent graduate of EMP Secretarial School, and I was in the top of my class. I am looking for a challenging work environment like that at NetLives.
Action	Tell what you plan to do.	I will call you next Monday to discuss my enclosed résumé.
Closing	Be positive.	I look forward to meeting with you soon.

Practice 1 Circle the letter of the sentence that is most similar to the sentence in the Model Cover Letter on page 2.

1. **Opening**
   a. I am applying for the position of administrative assistant.
   b. I need a job.
   c. I saw your advertisement for an administrative assistant in the November 14 *International Herald Tribune.*
2. **Focus**
   a. My work experience matches your requirements. I worked as an administrative assistant for two years.
   b. I'm a quick learner. I've never worked before.
   c. I have the skills required. I am familiar with word processing programs.
3. **Action**
   a. I will contact you early next week.
   b. I will call you on Tuesday morning to discuss the position.
   c. I'll be at home if you need me.
4. **Closing**
   a. Looks good, right?
   b. I look forward to working with NetLives.
   c. I look forward to talking to you next week.

That's Good Business!



Look at the NetLives advertisement on page 1. Ads often use abbreviations, such as *admin. asst.* for *administrative assistant.* Ads also use numerals (such as *2*) instead of spelling out words (*two*). Using abbreviations in ads saves space and money. Do not use abbreviations like this in a business letter.

Writing Your Message

Salutation

That's Good Business!



You want to make a good first impression with your cover letter. You want your letter to stand out from the others. Be positive. Let the employer know how you are suited for the job. Follow up your letter with a phone call.

- Write to a specific person. Before you write, try to find out the name (and gender) of the person you are writing to. You can call the company or check their Web site.

  Dear Ms. Maroon:

  Dear Mr. Ping:

- If you don't know the gender, use the person's full name or initial.

  Dear Lin Croft:

  Dear D. Maxon:

- If you don't know the name, use the person's title.

  Dear Human Resource Specialist:

  Dear Recruiter:

- If you know only the address, use a generic salutation.

  Good morning:

Practice 2 Write the salutation for a cover letter for the following jobs. Don't forget the colon.

	Position	Source	Contact
1.	Customer Service Representative	May 13 *Herald Tribune*	M. Pollard
2.	Administrative Assistant	A-Way.com Web site	recruiter@a-way.com
3.	Receptionist	IronGate.com Web site	Jane Bowles
4.	Executive Assistant	Word-of-mouth	Chee Yu

1. Dear M. Pollard: 3. _____

2. _____ 4. _____

Opening

In the opening of a cover letter, tell the reader two things: (1) what job you are applying for and (2) the source of your information.

Practice 3 Complete these opening sentences for cover letters for the jobs in Practice 2. Use the prepositions *about, for, in,* and *on*. Some prepositions will be used more than one time.

1. I saw your advertisement _____ a customer service representative _____ the May 13 *Herald Tribune*.
2. I am applying _____ the position of administrative assistant announced _____ the A-Way.com Web site.
3. _____ the IronGate.com Web site, I read _____ an opening _____ a receptionist.
4. Your colleague, Jannie Qin, told me _____ the executive assistant opening.

Focus

The body of a cover letter focuses on your skills. Briefly describe why you are suited for the job. Tell the reader how your skills match the job requirements.

Practice 4 Look at the skills you checked for the administrative assistant positions on page 1. Write sentences that describe your experience and skills and explain how you are suited for the job.

1. My work experience matches your requirements.
   I worked as an administrative assistant for two years.
2. My qualifications fit your needs. _____
3. My skills match the job requirements. _____
4. I have the skills required. _____
5. I meet the job requirements. _____

Action

Follow-up is very important. After you send a cover letter and résumé, contact the employer. In your cover letter, give either a general or a specific time that you will call or e-mail.

General I will call you *early next week.*
Specific I will call you *next Monday.*

Practice 5 Write *G* if the action has a general time or *S* if the action has a specific time.

1. ____ I will contact you early next week.
2. ____ I will call you on Tuesday morning to make an appointment.
3. ____ I will e-mail you next week to arrange an interview.
4. ____ On Friday, I will call your assistant to set up an interview.
5. ____ I will telephone you tomorrow to answer any questions you have.

Closing

In the closing, be sure to thank the reader for looking at your letter. Be positive. Mention a future conversation or meeting.

Practice 6 Rewrite these sentences using the expression *I look forward to* [+ *-ing* verb].

1. I want to work with IronGate.
   I look forward to working with IronGate.
2. I'd like to talk to you next week. _____
3. I'd like to meet with you. _____
4. I probably should discuss my interest in A-Way with you.
   _____
5. I hope I can contribute to your team. _____

Letter Practice 1

Complete the sentences in this letter. Use the job advertisement and the words below.

Changi News

July 2, 20—

File clerk wanted. Must have high school degree. Send résumé to Mr. Paul Rook, Human Resource Director, Island International Airport, Singapore 659589.

applying	forward	part-time	Resource
enclosed	interview	position	Sincerely

Well SAID

In this letter, the writer uses *2nd* in the date *July 2nd*. This is called an *ordinal number*. The number *2* alone is a *cardinal number*.

You can use either type of number in the body a letter, but in the date at the top always use a cardinal number (*July 17*).

Be consistent in your letter. If you use an ordinal number in one sentence, use ordinal numbers in the other sentences.

(*Write your address here.*) _____

July 17, 20—

Mr. Paul Rook

Human (1) _____ Director

Island International Airport

Singapore 659589

Dear Mr. Rook:

I am (2) _____ for the position of file clerk that was advertised in the July 2nd *Changi News*.

I worked as a (3) _____ file clerk after school for three years. Now I am looking for a full-time position. I have (4) _____ my résumé, and I would like to schedule an (5) _____. I will call you early next week to follow up on my application. I look (6) _____ to discussing this (7) _____ with you.

(8) _____ yours,

_____ (*Write your name here.*)

_____ (*Print your name here.*)

Enclosure

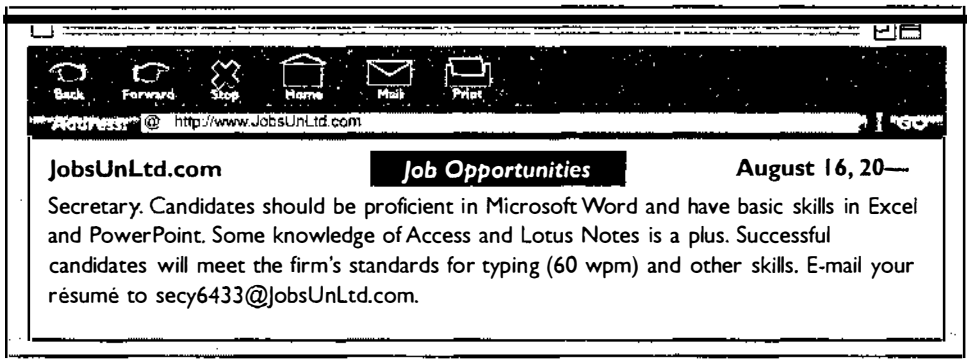
That's Good Business!



When you send material, such as a résumé, with a letter, add the word *Enclosure* at the end of the letter. You can write what is enclosed (*Enclosure: Résumé*), but it is not necessary.

Letter Practice 2

Liu Shia saw this job advertisement on a Web site and answered it. The shaded boxes show ten places where she made errors. Write the correct word or punctuation above the errors. The first one is done for you.



JobsUnLtd.com **Job Opportunities** **August 16, 20—**

Secretary. Candidates should be proficient in Microsoft Word and have basic skills in Excel and PowerPoint. Some knowledge of Access and Lotus Notes is a plus. Successful candidates will meet the firm's standards for typing (60 wpm) and other skills. E-mail your résumé to secy6433@JobsUnLtd.com.

Well SAID

The subject line is an important part of an e-mail. Be sure it clearly explains what the e-mail is about, and check it for mistakes before you send it.

To: secy6433@JobsUnLtd.com

(1) Subject: Secretarial Positioning *Position*

(2) Dear Recruiter,

(3), (4) I am responding for the secretarial vacancy posted on August 16 in your Web site.

(5) I have been an executive secretary since five years. I also have trained other

(6), (7) secretaryes how to use word processing and accounting software I type over 90 wpm, and I am very organized. I have attached my résumé to this e-mail.

(8), (9) I will e-mail you next week to follow up on my apply. I look forward to hear from you soon.

(10) Sincere yours,

Liu Shia

That's Good Business!



On Web sites, ads for job vacancies are *posted* (put on the Web site). The ad will tell you how to send your résumé. To send your résumé by e-mail, you can attach it as a file. Follow up to make sure the recipient was able to open your file.

Letter Practice 3

On a separate piece of paper, write responses to one of the following job advertisements.

Job Advertisement 1

Receptionist

Entry-level position for receptionist in dynamic construction company. You will enter data, greet customers, maintain database, and type memos. Prefer individual with good communication skills. Great compensation. Apply today!

Job Experience
Filing, General Office, Data Entry

Additional Information
Salary: $9.00 to $12.00 per hour

Contact Information
Account Executive,
myan@constructnow.com

Job Advertisement 2

Web Discount Corporation of Barcelona, Spain, seeks full-time Client Services Coordinator. Responsibilities include greeting clients, answering telephones, and performing other clerical functions.

REQUIREMENTS:

1. High school diploma and/or business college program
2. 2–4 years of clerical or administrative experience
3. Excellent organizational skills
4. Typing speed of 30 wpm
5. Word processing and database experience
6. Good communication skills

If you would like to work in an exciting environment, fax or e-mail your résumé to:
Pablo Cavero
Fax: 93 412 1044
E-mail: pcavero@webdiscount.org.es

Well SAID

Most people use one of two styles for writing dates.

U.S. style March 1, 20—
Non-U.S. style 1 March 20—

This book uses U.S. style. Of course, you should use your country's style when you write letters.

The month in a date is usually written out in a letter. In business forms, the month can be written as a number. Be sure it is clear which number is the month. In a letter, it may be unclear to use all numbers, especially if the writer and the reader use different styles.

U.S. style 03/01/03 is March 1, 2003
Non-U.S. style 03/01/03 is 3 January 2003

Words and Expressions to Know

Look at this list of words and expressions that were used in the unit. Their definitions are in the glossary at the end of the book.

attach	colleague	follow up	post	requirement
candidate	follow-up	opening	proficient	vacancy